SREENIDHI MODEL UNITED NATIONS

SMUN 2026 | COMMITTEE BACKGROUND GUIDE

INDIAN FILM INDUSTRY

IFI

Indian Film Industry

COMMITTEE AGENDA

Deliberation on Regulatory Reforms in the Indian Film Industry, with Special Emphasis on Film Certification, Age Verification, and Box Office Transparency.

Cinema • Cultural Expression • Industry Accountability

Message from the Secretariat

Dear Delegates,

Welcome to Sreenidhi Model United Nations 2026. The Secretariat is pleased to welcome you to the Indian Film Industry committee, where you will deliberate on regulatory reforms in the Indian film industry, with particular emphasis on film certification, age verification, and box-office transparency.

Cinema in India represents far more than entertainment. It is an important form of cultural expression, a significant commercial sector and a meeting point of creative freedom, public regulation, audience interests and industry investment. The committee's agenda requires you to examine how the rules governing exhibition and commercial disclosure can respond to changing technologies without overlooking India's linguistic and regional diversity.

The first area of consideration requires careful attention to the distinction between parental guidance and binding age restrictions, as well as the balance between protecting younger viewers and safeguarding artistic expression. The second requires a clear understanding of box-office measurements, verification, commercial confidentiality and the costs of imposing uniform reporting obligations across a diverse industry.

This Background Guide provides an introduction to the relevant legal framework, historical context and contemporary industry challenges. Delegates should use it as a foundation for independent research, consult the original statutory and institutional sources, and distinguish current legal requirements from reforms under consideration.

We encourage delegates to propose practical, evidence-based solutions that identify responsible institutions, implementation pathways and appropriate safeguards. We look forward to informed discussion, constructive negotiation and proposals that respect the creative and commercial significance of Indian cinema.

Warm regards,
The Secretariat
Sreenidhi Model United Nations 2026

Contents

Message from the Secretariat 2

Contents 3

01 Introduction to the Committee 4

02 Introduction to the Agenda 5

03 Explanation of the Agenda 7

04 Reference Links and Resources 13

05 Questions to Consider 15

A delegate guide to regulatory reforms in Indian cinema, audience protection and box-office transparency.

01 Introduction to the Committee

The Indian Film Industry is one of the world's major film-producing industries, comprising a diverse range of regional and national cinemas, including Hindi, Telugu, Tamil, Malayalam, Kannada, Bengali, Marathi and several other language industries. It contributes significantly to employment, cultural representation, technological development, international recognition and economic activity.

India's cinematic ecosystem includes filmmakers, actors, writers, producers, distributors, exhibitors, theatre owners, streaming platforms, certification authorities and audiences. Each participant has different responsibilities and interests, making the regulation of films and the reporting of their commercial performance important areas for discussion.

The Central Board of Film Certification (CBFC), functioning under the Ministry of Information and Broadcasting, is the statutory body responsible for certifying films for public exhibition in India. The certification framework operates under the Cinematograph Act, 1952, and the applicable rules and guidelines. The Cinematograph (Certification) Rules, 2024 introduced changes intended to modernise certification procedures, including age-based categories within the UA classification. These categories include UA 7+, UA 13+ and UA 16+, alongside U and A classifications. The age markers under the UA categories are advisory for parents or guardians rather than absolute legal admission thresholds. CBFC and Government of India information.

At the same time, the commercial performance of films is widely discussed through box-office collection figures. Producers, distributors, exhibitors and independent tracking organisations may publish different estimates because of differences in reporting methods, coverage, timing and the treatment of gross and net collections. The Competition Commission of India's study of the film distribution chain in India identified the lack of a uniform, industry-wide reporting system as a transparency concern. Competition Commission of India study.

The Indian Film Industry committee brings together the perspectives of the principal participants in the cinematic ecosystem. Delegates should debate the agenda as a set of interconnected questions of public policy and industry practice, while recognising that statutory regulatory powers belong to the relevant public authorities rather than to this simulated committee.

02 Introduction to the Agenda

Film Certification and Age Verification

Film certification determines the classification under which a film may be publicly exhibited. Its purpose is not simply to restrict content; it also helps audiences and parents make informed viewing decisions while balancing public interests with artistic expression.

The introduction of age-based UA classifications in India represents an effort to provide more specific guidance about the suitability of films for younger viewers. However, certification alone may not ensure that audiences are consistently informed about a film's content or that age-related admission policies are applied appropriately across cinemas.

This agenda invites delegates to consider whether the current system provides sufficient clarity, consistency and accountability. It also raises questions about the role of cinema operators, ticket-booking platforms, parents and guardians, and public authorities in communicating ratings and applying relevant rules.

Reform proposals may include clearer rating explanations, standardised display of age classifications, better public awareness, consistent procedures for checking age where legally required, and safeguards against excessive or arbitrary restrictions on access to films.

The central challenge is to establish a system that protects children from unsuitable content without treating all audiences identically, undermining artistic freedom or imposing impractical obligations on exhibitors.

National Box Office Reporting and Revenue Transparency

Box-office reporting refers to the collection, verification and publication of information about ticket sales and the revenue generated by films in cinemas. Such information can influence audience perception, investment decisions, distribution agreements, marketing strategies and the assessment of a film's commercial performance.

In India, box-office figures are published through several channels, including production-house announcements, distributor statements, cinema-related data, trade publications and independent tracking organisations. These figures may differ because they do not always use identical definitions, reporting periods or methods of calculation.

A further complication is the distinction between gross box-office collections, which represent ticket-sale revenue before specified deductions, and net box-office collections, which account for applicable deductions such as entertainment taxes where relevant. Box-office revenue should also not be confused with a film's profit: production costs, marketing expenses, distribution arrangements, theatre revenue

shares, streaming rights and other income streams affect the financial outcome.

A national framework could establish common definitions, reporting standards, verification procedures and disclosure requirements. Its purpose would be to improve confidence in published figures while respecting legitimate commercial confidentiality and avoiding unnecessary burdens on smaller businesses.

The Competition Commission of India's study of the film distribution chain examined concerns surrounding inconsistent box-office reporting and discussed monitoring systems and independent auditing as possible responses. The committee can use this as a starting point for considering whether a common framework should be voluntary, industry-led, government-supported or legally mandated.

These policy dimensions are connected by the need for accurate information and institutions that command public trust. The first concerns how audiences understand and act upon classifications; the second concerns how audiences, investors and industry participants understand reported theatrical collections.

03 Explanation of the Agenda

3.1 Historical Context: Film Regulation and Exhibition in India

India’s statutory film-certification system developed under the Cinematograph Act, 1952. As film exhibition expanded across languages, regions and exhibition formats, public debate increasingly addressed the relationship between government certification, cultural sensitivities, artistic expression and access to cinema. Judicial scrutiny and legislative changes have also influenced the procedures and standards through which films are certified for public exhibition.

The Cinematograph (Amendment) Act, 2023 and the Cinematograph (Certification) Rules, 2024 form part of the more recent reform context. The certification system now includes the U, UA 7+, UA 13+, UA 16+, A and S categories. Delegates must distinguish the advisory age markers within the UA classifications from age-based admission restrictions associated with other classifications under the applicable framework.

3.2 Certification Categories and Audience Information

Whether existing certification categories communicate the nature and intensity of a film's content clearly enough.

Whether age classifications should be accompanied by more detailed content descriptors, such as violence, frightening scenes, sexual content or substance use.

How certification standards can remain consistent while recognising India's linguistic, cultural and social diversity.

Whether certification decisions and appeals should be supported by clearer reasoning and transparent procedures.

Clear and consistent content guidance can help viewers and parents make informed decisions. Reform options include standardised category displays, content descriptors and accessible information about the effect of a particular certificate. Any change should identify the actual legal position and avoid presenting recommendations as already enforceable rules.

3.3 Age Verification, Minors and Operational Enforcement

Whether cinemas should adopt standard procedures for verifying age when a film's classification requires an age restriction.

How online ticketing platforms and cinema operators should communicate admission requirements before a ticket is purchased.

Whether age verification should be based on uniform national guidance or allow reasonable operational flexibility.

How cinemas can avoid inconsistent enforcement between venues, cities and states.

Protection of minors and parental responsibility

Whether stronger public information and parental guidance can improve informed viewing decisions.

How to distinguish advisory age markers from legally enforceable age restrictions.

Whether parents and guardians should receive accessible information about a film's content before attending a screening.

How safeguards can be designed without unnecessarily excluding young audiences from culturally or educationally significant films.

For screenings subject to legally operative age restrictions, exhibitors and ticketing platforms may need workable checking procedures. Any proposed system should avoid collecting unnecessary identity data, provide accessible non-digital alternatives and account for the operational realities of small single-screen theatres as well as large multiplex chains.

3.4 Creative Freedom, Accountability and Review

How certification can protect audiences without becoming a mechanism for unnecessary censorship.

What standards should guide decisions involving sensitive political, historical, social or religious themes.

How filmmakers can challenge certification decisions through fair and transparent procedures.

Whether ticketing platforms should display certification categories and relevant age guidance prominently.

How personal information collected during age checks should be protected.

Whether digital verification systems could create barriers for people without smartphones, digital identity tools or easy access to documentation.

How smaller cinemas and independent exhibitors could implement new requirements without disproportionate financial burdens.

The committee should consider how certification decisions can be explained, reviewed and challenged without reducing artistic expression to administrative discretion. Relevant concerns include procedural fairness, published reasons, consistent application of standards, and safeguards against unnecessary or discriminatory exclusion.

“Cinema is a matter of what’s in the frame and what’s out.” — Martin Scorsese

3.5 Origins of the Box-Office Transparency Debate

Box-office collections are not reported through a single uniformly verified national system. Producers, distributors, exhibitors and independent analysts may use different methods to estimate admissions and earnings. These practices can make comparisons difficult, particularly across regions and between multiplex and single-screen cinema markets. The Competition Commission of India’s market study on the film distribution chain provides a foundation for examining these problems and possible monitoring or audit arrangements.

3.6 Common Definitions and Reporting Standards

Whether a common national definition of gross collections, net collections, domestic collections and worldwide collections should be adopted.

How reports should distinguish Indian theatrical revenue from overseas collections, streaming rights, satellite rights, music rights and other revenue streams.

Whether collection figures should be reported daily, weekly, over a film's theatrical run, or through a combination of reporting periods.

How figures should account for refunds, complimentary tickets, promotional offers, cancelled shows and differences in ticket prices.

Gross box-office receipts, net receipts, admissions, distributor share and producer profitability are not interchangeable concepts. Any unified reporting framework should define its units and reporting periods precisely, distinguish domestic from overseas earnings, and clarify the treatment of discounts, taxes, cancellations and complimentary admissions.

3.7 Verification, Independent Audits and National Infrastructure

Whether cinemas should use standardised digital ticketing and reporting systems.

Whether an independent body should verify reported figures or audit the systems used to generate them.

How data should be checked when producers, distributors, exhibitors and independent trackers publish conflicting numbers.

What consequences, if any, should apply when reporting is deliberately misleading.

How to ensure that verification remains independent and does not favour particular studios, distributors or cinema chains.

National reporting infrastructure

Whether a unified national reporting portal or database should be established.

Which organisation should oversee the system and how its independence should be protected.

How data from multiplexes, single-screen cinemas and smaller regional markets could be incorporated.

Whether reporting requirements should be mandatory for all exhibitors or introduced gradually according to size and capacity.

How data security, commercially sensitive information and access rights should be managed.

Delegates should assess whether verified ticket-level information could be aggregated nationally, whether reporting would be voluntary or mandatory, and who should supervise the system. An effective model would need appropriate technological safeguards, a fair correction procedure and a credible mechanism for independent oversight.

3.8 Competition, Commercial Confidentiality and Regional Inclusion

How reliable box-office figures could support fairer negotiations between producers, distributors and exhibitors.

Whether transparent reporting would improve investor confidence and reduce disputes over revenue-sharing agreements.

How to prevent a reporting framework from becoming a tool for market manipulation or unfair competitive advantage.

Whether smaller producers and regional industries could benefit from more reliable performance data.

Audience trust and public communication

Whether publicly reported figures should be accompanied by clear definitions and information about their verification status.

How to distinguish audited figures, reported figures, estimates and projections.

Whether claims such as “worldwide gross” or “net collection” should follow standard disclosure rules.

How a common framework could reduce confusion without unnecessarily restricting legitimate film promotion.

Regional representation and accessibility

How a national system can account for the linguistic and commercial diversity of Indian cinema.

Whether smaller regional films receive less visibility because their collections are not tracked as consistently as those of major releases.

How to avoid a framework that imposes disproportionate costs on independent producers and smaller theatres.

Whether aggregated reporting could improve understanding of audience demand beyond a small number of high-grossing films.

"Once you overcome the one-inch-tall barrier of subtitles, you will be introduced to so many more amazing films." — Bong Joon Ho

3.9 Current Challenges and Emerging Industry Pressures

The central implementation challenges across the agenda arise from the diversity of the exhibition market, the growing role of digital ticketing, uneven technological capacity, differing contractual practices and public confusion about rating labels and revenue claims. The emergence of online distribution raises additional questions about how theatrical certification relates to content classification in other media, although the statutory regimes are not identical.

Policy changes may be difficult to implement uniformly in smaller venues, regional-language markets and markets where ticketing or reporting infrastructure is less developed. The committee must weigh the benefits of stronger regulation against compliance costs, data protection, market concentration and unintended burdens on independent producers and exhibitors.

3.10 Current Institutional Responses and Options for Reform

The existing response to film certification is primarily statutory, through the Cinematograph Act, its amendments, the relevant rules, the Central Board of Film Certification and government administration. The more recent classifications provide differentiated parental guidance, while debate continues over how such information is displayed, understood and applied at the point of ticket purchase and entry.

For box-office reporting, the Competition Commission of India's market study and existing industry tracking practices provide starting points for discussion rather than a comprehensive national legal reporting mandate. Possible reforms include common industry definitions, a standardised reporting portal, independent verification, audited reporting labels, data-access safeguards and phased implementation for smaller exhibitors. Delegates should distinguish current institutional practices from proposals that would require additional legal or administrative authority.

3.11 Feasibility, Implementation and Institutional Responsibility

Delegates should research the legal, institutional, economic and practical dimensions of both agendas before proposing reforms. Background research should identify the existing system, the problem being addressed, the institutions with authority to act and the consequences of potential policy changes.

For film certification, delegates should understand the Cinematograph Act, 1952, the Cinematograph (Certification) Rules, 2024, the current certification categories and the distinction between advisory age

guidance and legally enforceable admission requirements. Proposals should identify the exact gap they intend to address rather than assuming that the entire framework must be replaced.

For age verification, delegates should investigate the respective roles of certification authorities, cinema operators, ticketing platforms, parents and guardians. Solutions should consider accessibility, privacy, cost, consistency and the possibility of unintended restrictions on audiences.

For box-office reporting, delegates should study the difference between gross and net collections, domestic and worldwide figures, ticket sales and other film-related revenue. Delegates should also examine the Competition Commission of India's findings and consider how standard definitions, reporting systems and independent audits could be implemented.

Every proposed mechanism should identify its responsible authority, scope, implementation process, funding requirements and accountability measures. Delegates should be prepared to explain how their proposals would work in both major multiplex chains and smaller cinemas, including regional-language markets.

Research should draw on official legal documents, government publications, competition-regulator studies, credible industry reports and reputable journalism. When sources report different figures, delegates should identify the reporting period, geographic scope, methodology and whether the figures are estimates or verified data.

Delegates should avoid presenting allegations as established facts, treating industry estimates as audited accounts or confusing certification with censorship. All proposals should be practical, evidence-based and respectful of India's linguistic diversity, audience interests, commercial realities and creative freedom.

Delegates should develop resolutions that identify which actor could implement each measure, whether legislation or subordinate rules would need amendment, how an industry-led alternative might operate and how outcomes could be measured without excessive regulatory intervention.

04 Reference Links and Resources

The following research resources are retained from the original IFI background document and grouped by subject. Hyperlinks are active. Verify current versions of laws, official notices and industry studies before relying on them in debate.

Film Certification and Age Verification

01. **Central Board of Film Certification (CBFC)**

Official information about film certification, categories, procedures and relevant notices.

02. **Ministry of Information and Broadcasting — Cinematograph (Certification) Rules, 2024**

Government material explaining the rules governing the certification process.

03. **Press Information Bureau — Age-based film certification categories**

Explanation of the U, UA 7+, UA 13+, UA 16+ and A categories.

04. **Cinematograph Act and certification framework**

Background on the legal framework and the principles governing certification.

05. **Ministry of Information and Broadcasting — Film Wing**

Information about film-related institutions and government responsibilities.

Box-Office Reporting and Revenue Transparency

06. **Competition Commission of India — Market Study on the Film Distribution Chain in India**

A key resource for understanding reporting inconsistencies, industry relationships, competition and possible monitoring mechanisms.

07. **Ministry of Information and Broadcasting — Economic Impact of the Film, Television and Online Curated Content Industry in India, 2024**

Industry-wide information about the economic contribution of cinema, revenue streams and box-office trends.

08. **Ormax Media — The Ormax Box Office Report 2025**

A source for reported domestic box-office trends and the differences between ticket revenue, footfalls and average ticket prices.

09. **Box Office India — Frequently Asked Questions**

An example of how an independent box-office reporting source explains its methods and differences between reported figures.

10. **Press Information Bureau — Film distribution and box-office monitoring recommendations**

Government-published material discussing box-office monitoring systems, ticketing logs and independent audits.

Cinema, Creative Freedom and International Recognition

11. **Academy of Motion Picture Arts and Sciences**

Information about the Academy's mission, film history, inclusion and the recognition of excellence in filmmaking.

12. **Academy Awards**

Official information about the awards and their recipients.

13. **Reuters — Film and entertainment reporting**

International reporting on cinema, film regulation, industry economics and entertainment-sector developments. Search for relevant reports rather than assuming every article addresses these specific agendas.

05 Questions to Consider

Film Certification and Age Verification

01. Does India's current film-certification framework adequately communicate age suitability to audiences?
02. Should content descriptors accompany age classifications to help parents make informed decisions?
03. How should the committee distinguish advisory UA age markers from legally enforceable age restrictions?
04. What responsibilities should cinemas and online ticketing platforms have in communicating certification categories?
05. Should standard age-verification procedures be introduced for screenings where admission is legally restricted?
06. How can age verification be implemented without collecting excessive personal information?
07. What safeguards should exist against arbitrary, inconsistent or discriminatory enforcement?
08. How can certification decisions remain transparent and open to fair review?
09. What support would smaller cinemas need to implement new procedures?
10. How can the framework protect young audiences without unnecessarily restricting creative expression?

National Box Office Reporting and Revenue Transparency

01. Should India establish a unified national framework for reporting theatrical collections?
02. Which organisation should oversee the framework, and how could its independence be protected?
03. Should reporting requirements apply to every cinema or be introduced in stages?
04. What definitions should be used for gross, net, domestic and worldwide box-office collections?
05. Should reported figures be independently audited or verified through standardised digital systems?
06. How should the framework address differences between producer announcements and independently reported estimates?
07. What information should be public, and what commercial information should remain confidential?
08. How could smaller cinemas and regional-language industries participate without disproportionate costs?

Cross-Cutting Questions for Deliberation

01. What is the current legal and institutional framework governing the agenda assigned to you?
02. Which problems are already addressed by existing rules, and where do gaps remain?
03. Which institutions have the legal authority and practical capacity to implement your proposed reforms?

04. What evidence supports your assessment of the problem?

05. Which stakeholders would benefit from your proposal, and which might face additional costs or restrictions?

06. How would your proposal affect independent filmmakers, regional-language cinema, small exhibitors and audiences?

07. What safeguards would prevent misuse, arbitrary enforcement or conflicts of interest?

08. How would the proposed mechanism be funded, monitored and evaluated?

09. What alternatives could achieve the same objective with fewer costs or restrictions?

10. How would your delegation respond to concerns about privacy, commercial confidentiality, creative freedom or regulatory overreach?

11. Which provisions would require amendments to existing legislation, and which could be implemented through administrative guidance or industry standards?

12. What measurable indicators would demonstrate that your proposal is working?